



ONE OF THE EARLIEST athletic competitions for women was the Heraean Games in ancient Greece, held in honor of the goddess Hera. This 6th-century BCE event took place in Olympia and focused on foot races. Held in Olympia too, the ancient Olympic Games featured a wider range of sports than today's competition, but were for men only. When the Olympics were revived in 1896, women were still not allowed to compete, and even when they began to take part in 1900,

their participation was limited to a select few events. Thanks to activists such as Alice Milliat (see right) in France, female involvement increased through the 20th century, but it was only at the 2012 London Olympics that women could compete in every sport at the summer games.

Historically, not all sports were segregated. In 3rd-century BCE China, both men and women played an early form of football called *cuju*, in which the aim was to kick a ball through a goal. A version called *baida*, where points were given for skill in controlling the ball, was also popular among women. Modern soccer emerged in the late 19th century, and women took up the sport in high numbers, but local and international bodies restricted their involvement. From 1921–71, the English Football Association banned member clubs from allowing women's teams to use their stadiums. The first women's World Cup only

THROUGH THE AGES

Sport

To participate and compete at both professional and amateur levels, sportswomen have had to fight for equal opportunities. Although today far higher numbers of women take part across a wider range of sporting activities than ever before, the struggle for parity in pay and media coverage continues.

“Throwing **70 miles per hour**—that's **throwing like a girl**.”

MO'NE DAVIS, BASEBALL PLAYER

► Acing the game

American tennis player Helen Jacobs won nine Grand Slam titles during her career, including the US Championships' singles on four occasions. She was the first woman to break with tradition and wear men's shorts at Wimbledon in 1933.

